BHOPAL TOXIC WASTE DISPOSAL

BURNING RESISTANCE



ANTI-DUMP DISSENT Residents protest against waste disposal at Pithampur, Jan. 2

By Rahul Noronha

The 337 tonnes of toxic waste from the abandoned Union Carbide plant in Bhopal, awaiting disposal for four decades, has hit a roadblock. Opposition from locals in Pithampur, an industrial town 250 km away in Dhar district, has forced the Madhya Pradesh government to temporarily halt the incineration process. The toxic waste is among the most enduring legacies of the 1984 tragedy, in which a leak of methyl isocyanate gas killed nearly 5,500 people and injured over half a million in the state capital.

The protest comes after the MP High Court's December 3, 2024, order, coinciding with the 40th anniversary of the Bhopal gas tragedy—one of the world's worst industrial disasters. The court directed the state to clear the waste within four weeks, backed by a Union government grant of Rs 126 crore. Pithampur-based Ramkey Environment Engineers Limited was chosen to handle the scientific disposal.

The operation began on December 27, with the toxic waste packed into containers and transported in 10 special trucks that reached Pithampur on January 2. However, the plan met stiff resistance from locals, who feared potential harm to their environment and water sources. A bandh on January 3 escalated into protests, with demonstrators clashing with the police. Two individuals even attempted self-immolation, sustaining severe burns. Amid growing unrest, Chief Minister Mohan Yadav announced a suspension of the disposal the next day, citing the need to address public concerns.

PITHAMPUR LOCALS FEAR THAT BURYING UNION CARBIDE WASTE WILL HARM THE ENVIRONMENT AND WATER SOURCES

On January 6, the government informed the high court of the situation and that some unverified media reports fuelled fears of another industrial catastrophe, securing a six-week extension to comply with its original order. The court then directed the media to not publish news without a strong basis.

The anti-incineration sentiment, though initially fragmented, gained traction due to past failures. Of the seven test runs conducted since 2010, five failed, with the last in 2015 sparking concerns. A local newspaper report last month linking the trial to reduced crop yields and groundwater contamination further galvanised opposition. Efforts by the administration to reassure locals fell flat, while doctors in nearby Indore raised health concerns and joined the legal battle as interveners.

Activists representing the victims of the disaster criticised the transportation method, claiming the waste should have been secured in steel containers, and argued that the costs of disposal should adhere to the "polluter pays" principle. "Burying after incineration is not the best option. Also, Union Carbide should have been asked to bear the incineration expenses as is the practice worldwide," says Rachna Dhingra of the Bhopal Group for Information and Action.

Though the Bhopal plant site is free of toxic waste now, the government still faces the challenge of building consensus. "We will explain to the residents that the disposal will be done scientifically, ensuring complete transparency," says Priyank Mishra, district magistrate, Dhar. "We have posted the Central Pollution Control Board's report on the 2015 trial incineration online." Balancing public sentiment with court directives will be crucial if the government has to resolve the issue. ■